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The terminological categories, as an aspect of the kinship system, serve partly as status markers. They indicate joking and avoidance/respect relationships and relationships that preclude marriage. The G/wi kinship system is present-oriented in that it includes neither past nor unborn generations in lineages but encompasses only living personnel. It is a means of ordering the relationships of the living in their present circumstances and tends to obliterate the details of the circumstances of past generations. Its present orientation places the system outside the relevance of “descent theory” and the lineage principle of Radcliffe-Brown (1950:Introduction).

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As I have argued, there is no formal structure that meaningfully predicts the probability of marriage between specific individuals. The marriage system is an open one, which precludes marriage between certain individuals but does not prescribe which marriages shall take place. The population is dispersed in widely separated bands, the membership of which is not structurally determined. Sex ratios, age structures, and the proportions of permitted and prohibited marriage partners (this aspect is discussed in the final chapter) vary among bands. Geographical barriers make communication difficult, and the field in which a spouse might be sought is limited and demographically unpredictable. G/wi marriages carry a heavy functional load, are subject to severe strain during the privations of the isolation phase, and lack the firm social and/or economic supportive mechanisms found in other marriage systems (e.g., the Nguni institution of which functions to stabilize marriages). The G/wi marriage system meets the demographic problem by allowing a fairly wide choice of spouse (see the final chapter) but leaves the narrower selection to more discriminating, nonstructural criteria (e.g., relative age, social maturity, psychological compatibility). The system appears to achieve optimal flexibility in the order that it imposes and to favor the chances of the marriage surviving the trying circumstances that it must

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endure. It is, however, an unspecialized system in that it does not rely wholly on selection criteria. There are "fail-safe, backup" mechanisms in the institution of divorce, which is uncomplicated, informal, and free of stigma, and in the ease with which divorcees may remarry (note also the institutions of levirate and sororate in this respect). In the ecological situation of the G/wi, marriage is essential to survival as it prescribes complementary economic roles of spouses and imposes economic and psychosocial obligations ■ 185 on parents. The marriage system ensures perpetuation of the social group of husband, wife, parents, children, that is, the household, rather than seeking only to perpetuate the marriage of two individuals to each other. In other words, the system functions primarily to ensure the survival of the household, which, as I have indicated, is the most stable of the social groups.

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